

VOCABULARY · EXAMPLES · ACTIVITIES

FOODIE DICTIONARY

El diccionario del buen comer

Markets, kitchens, tables and traditional dishes,
with Spain 🇪🇸 and Argentina 🇦🇷 vocabulary

PONCHO
SPANISH

¡BUEN PROVECHO!

In Spain and Argentina, food is never just food. It is how families gather, how friends catch up and how a long afternoon turns into a memorable one.

This dictionary brings together more than 80 words and expressions for shopping, cooking, tasting and eating out, each with a natural example sentence. You'll also find the classic dishes of both countries and the phrases people use around the table.

It is written for adult learners who love good food, whether you are planning a trip, cooking at home or simply want to order with confidence next time.

How to use it

1. **Read the word, then the sentence.** Context is what makes vocabulary stay.
2. **Cook with it.** Label your ingredients in Spanish or follow a recipe from Spain or Argentina.
3. **Order in Spanish** at your next tapas bar or parrilla, even if it's just one dish.
4. **Finish with the activities** and check your answers at the end.

Two countries, two words

The kitchen is where Spain and Argentina differ most. When you see two options, the first is common in Spain 🇪🇸 and the second in Argentina 🇦🇷. Both are correct.

la patata 🇪🇸 = **la papa** 🇦🇷

Pescado or pez?

Spanish has two words for fish: **el pez** is the animal swimming in the sea and **el pescado** is the fish on your plate. You buy **pescado** at the market, never **peces**, unless you want a pet!

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01

EN EL MERCADO

AT THE MARKET

Fruit, vegetables and the conversation that comes with buying them.

ESPAÑOL	ENGLISH	EN UNA FRASE
la fruta	fruit	*La fruta de temporada es más barata.* Seasonal fruit is cheaper.
la verdura	vegetables	*Compro la verdura los sábados.* I buy vegetables on Saturdays.
la patata 🇪🇸 la papa 🇦🇷	the potato	*Un kilo de patatas, por favor.* A kilo of potatoes, please.
el tomate	the tomato	*Estos tomates son de la huerta.* These tomatoes are home-grown.
el aguacate 🇪🇸 la palta 🇦🇷	the avocado	*¿Tiene aguacates maduros?* Do you have ripe avocados?
la fresa 🇪🇸 la frutilla 🇦🇷	the strawberry	*Las fresas están dulcísimas.* The strawberries are really sweet.
el melocotón 🇪🇸 el durazno 🇦🇷	the peach	*Me llevo medio kilo de melocotones.* I'll take half a kilo of peaches.
el plátano 🇪🇸 la banana 🇦🇷	the banana	*Los plátanos de Canarias son pequeños.* Canary Island bananas are small.
la piña 🇪🇸 el ananá 🇦🇷	the pineapple	*La piña está en oferta.* The pineapple is on offer.
el pimiento 🇪🇸 el morrón 🇦🇷	the pepper	*Un pimiento rojo y uno verde.* One red pepper and one green one.
los guisantes 🇪🇸 las arvejas 🇦🇷	peas	*Ponle guisantes al arroz.* Put some peas in the rice.

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01 · EN EL MERCADO AT THE MARKET

ESPAÑOL	ENGLISH	EN UNA FRASE
las judías verdes 🇪🇸 las chauchas 🇦🇷	green beans	*Las judías verdes se cocinan al vapor.* Green beans are steamed.
el maíz 🇪🇸 el choclo 🇦🇷	corn, sweetcorn	*El maíz a la parrilla está buenísimo.* Grilled corn is delicious.
maduro	ripe	*Este melón todavía no está maduro.* This melon isn't ripe yet.
de temporada	in season	*Las naranjas son de temporada en invierno.* Oranges are in season in winter.

¿SABÍAS QUE...?

Spanish market stalls often let you choose by asking '¿Me pone medio kilo?' and the stallholder picks the best for you. Saying when you'll eat it, 'para hoy' or 'para el fin de semana', helps them choose fruit at just the right ripeness.

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02

CARNES, PESCADOS Y MÁS

MEAT, FISH AND DAIRY

If you eat meat or fish, these words will help you order exactly what you like. If you don't, the first two lines are for you: everyone is welcome at the Spanish table.

ESPAÑOL	ENGLISH	EN UNA FRASE
Soy vegetariano / vegetariana.	I'm vegetarian.	*Soy vegetariana, ¿qué platos no llevan carne?* I'm vegetarian, which dishes have no meat?
Soy vegano / vegana.	I'm vegan.	*Soy vegano, ¿esto lleva huevo o leche?* I'm vegan, does this have egg or milk in it?
la carne	meat	*¿Este plato lleva carne?* Does this dish have meat in it?
la carne de vaca 🇪🇸 la carne vacuna 🇦🇷	beef	*Prefiero la carne de vaca a la plancha.* I prefer grilled beef.
el cerdo	pork	*Sin cerdo, por favor.* No pork, please.
el pollo	chicken	*Hoy cenamos pollo asado.* We're having roast chicken tonight.
el filete 🇪🇸 el bife 🇦🇷	the steak	*Un filete poco hecho, por favor.* A rare steak, please.
el pescado	fish (to eat)	*Los viernes comemos pescado.* We eat fish on Fridays.
las gambas 🇪🇸 los camarones 🇦🇷	prawns	*Gambas al ajillo para compartir.* Garlic prawns to share.
el marisco 🇪🇸 los mariscos 🇦🇷	seafood, shellfish	*En Galicia el marisco es increíble.* The seafood in Galicia is incredible.
el queso	cheese	*Un queso manchego curado, por favor.* A mature Manchego cheese, please.

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02 · CARNES, PESCADOS Y MÁS MEAT, FISH AND DAIRY

ESPAÑOL	ENGLISH	EN UNA FRASE
la mantequilla 🇪🇸 la manteca 🇦🇷	butter	*Tostadas con mantequilla y mermelada.* Toast with butter and jam.
la nata 🇪🇸 la crema 🇦🇷	cream	*Fresas con nata de postre.* Strawberries and cream for pudding.
el huevo	the egg	*Una docena de huevos camperos.* A dozen free-range eggs.

¿SABÍAS QUE...?

Be careful with manteca: in Argentina it means butter, but in Spain manteca is lard. Ask for mantequilla in Spain or you might get a surprise on your toast!

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03

EN LA COCINA

IN THE KITCHEN

Verbs, utensils and the language of following a recipe.

ESPAÑOL	ENGLISH	EN UNA FRASE
cocinar	to cook	*Mi padre cocina los domingos.* My dad cooks on Sundays.
la receta	the recipe	*Es la receta de mi abuela.* It's my grandmother's recipe.
cortar	to cut	*Corta la cebolla muy fina.* Slice the onion very thinly.
pelar	to peel	*Pela las patatas y córtalas en dados.* Peel the potatoes and dice them.
freír	to fry	*Fríe los huevos en aceite de oliva.* Fry the eggs in olive oil.
hervir	to boil	*Hierve el agua con un poco de sal.* Boil the water with a little salt.
hornear	to bake	*Hornea el bizcocho durante cuarenta minutos.* Bake the sponge for forty minutes.
a la plancha	grilled (on a hotplate)	*Calamares a la plancha con limón.* Grilled squid with lemon.
la sartén	the frying pan	*Calienta el aceite en la sartén.* Heat the oil in the frying pan.
la olla	the pot, the saucepan	*Pon las lentejas en la olla.* Put the lentils in the pot.
el horno	the oven	*El pollo está en el horno.* The chicken is in the oven.

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03 · EN LA COCINA IN THE KITCHEN

ESPAÑOL	ENGLISH	EN UNA FRASE
el aceite de oliva	olive oil	*Un chorrito de aceite de oliva.* A drizzle of olive oil.
la nevera 🇪🇸 la heladera 🇦🇷	the fridge	*Guarda el postre en la nevera.* Keep the pudding in the fridge.
probar	to taste, to try	*Prueba la salsa, ¿le falta sal?* Taste the sauce, does it need salt?
una pizca de	a pinch of	*Añade una pizca de pimentón.* Add a pinch of paprika.

¿SABÍAS QUE...?

Spanish has a lovely word for a small splash of liquid: un chorrito. Recipes passed down in families rarely give exact amounts; they say un chorrito de aceite or una pizca de sal and trust the cook.

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04

SABORES Y TEXTURAS

DESCRIBING FOOD

How to say what you love (and what you don't) about a dish.

ESPAÑOL	ENGLISH	EN UNA FRASE
rico / riquísimo	tasty / delicious	*¡Esta paella está riquísima!* This paella is delicious!
dulce	sweet	*El dulce de leche es muy dulce.* Dulce de leche is very sweet.
salado	salty, savoury	*La sopa está un poco salada.* The soup is a bit salty.
picante	spicy, hot	*¿La salsa es picante?* Is the sauce spicy?
ácido	sour, sharp	*El limón es muy ácido.* Lemon is very sour.
amargo	bitter	*El mate sin azúcar es amargo.* Mate without sugar is bitter.
crujiente	crunchy, crispy	*Las patatas están muy crujientes.* The chips are really crispy.
tierno	tender	*La carne está tiernísima.* The meat is so tender.
jugoso	juicy	*Me gusta el bife jugoso.* I like my steak juicy.
casero	homemade	*Todo el pan es casero.* All the bread is homemade.
soso 🇪🇸 insulso 🇦🇷	bland	*Le falta sal, está un poco soso.* It needs salt, it's a bit bland.

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04 · SABORES Y TEXTURAS DESCRIBING FOOD

ESPAÑOL	ENGLISH	EN UNA FRASE
caliente / frío	hot / cold	*El gazpacho se toma frío.* Gazpacho is served cold.
estar en su punto	to be cooked just right	*El arroz está en su punto.* The rice is cooked just right.
¡Qué buena pinta! / ¡Qué buena pinta tiene!	That looks great!	*¡Qué buena pinta tiene esa tarta!* That cake looks great!

¿SABÍAS QUE...?

In Spain, a dish that looks appetising tiene buena pinta. In Argentina, people often say está para chuparse los dedos, good enough to lick your fingers, which is also said in Spain.

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05

EN EL BAR Y EL RESTAURANTE

AT THE BAR AND RESTAURANT

Ordering, sharing and paying like a local.

ESPAÑOL	ENGLISH	EN UNA FRASE
reservar mesa	to book a table	*Hay que reservar mesa el sábado.* You need to book a table on Saturday.
la terraza	the outdoor seating area	*¿Nos sentamos en la terraza?* Shall we sit outside?
la carta de vinos	the wine list	*¿Nos enseña la carta de vinos?* Could you show us the wine list?
el primer plato 🇪🇸 la entrada 🇦🇷	the starter	*De primero, una ensalada.* For a starter, a salad.
el segundo plato 🇪🇸 el plato principal 🇦🇷	the main course	*De segundo, merluza al horno.* For the main course, baked hake.
el postre	dessert	*¿Qué hay de postre?* What's for dessert?
una caña 🇪🇸	a small glass of draught beer	*Dos cañas y unas olivas.* Two small beers and some olives.
una copa de vino tinto	a glass of red wine	*Para mí, una copa de vino tinto.* For me, a glass of red wine.
un cortado	a coffee with a dash of milk	*Un cortado y la cuenta, por favor.* A cortado and the bill, please.
compartir	to share	*Pedimos varios platos para compartir.* We ordered several dishes to share.
la ración 🇪🇸 la porción 🇦🇷	the portion	*Una ración de croquetas.* A portion of croquettes.

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05 · EN EL BAR Y EL RESTAURANTE AT THE BAR AND RESTAURANT

ESPAÑOL	ENGLISH	EN UNA FRASE
sin gluten	gluten-free	*¿Tienen opciones sin gluten?* Do you have gluten-free options?
invitar	to treat someone, to pay	*Hoy invito yo.* It's my treat today.
pagar a medias	to split the bill	*¿Pagamos a medias?* Shall we split the bill?

¿SABÍAS QUE...?

In Argentina the coffee is part of the culture: a café con leche with medialunas, little sweet croissants, is the classic breakfast in any Buenos Aires café, and people can sit for hours over a single cup.

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06

PLATOS TÍPICOS

CLASSIC DISHES

The dishes everyone should try at least once.

ESPAÑOL	ENGLISH	EN UNA FRASE
la paella 🇪🇸	paella	*La paella valenciana lleva pollo y conejo.* Valencian paella has chicken and rabbit.
la tortilla de patatas 🇪🇸	Spanish omelette	*¿La tortilla, con cebolla o sin cebolla?* The omelette: with onion or without?
el gazpacho 🇪🇸	cold tomato soup	*En verano tomamos gazpacho.* In summer we have gazpacho.
las croquetas 🇪🇸	croquettes	*Las croquetas de jamón son mis favoritas.* Ham croquettes are my favourite.
los churros	churros	*Churros con chocolate para desayunar.* Churros with hot chocolate for breakfast.
el asado 🇦🇷	Argentinian barbecue	*El domingo hay asado en casa.* On Sunday there's an asado at home.
las empanadas	empanadas, savoury pasties	*Una docena de empanadas de carne.* A dozen beef empanadas.
la milanesa 🇦🇷	breaded steak or chicken	*La milanesa con puré es un clásico.* Milanesa with mash is a classic.
el chimichurri 🇦🇷	herb and garlic sauce	*Ponle chimichurri a las verduras asadas.* Put chimichurri on the grilled vegetables.
el dulce de leche 🇦🇷	milk caramel	*Tostadas con dulce de leche.* Toast with dulce de leche.
el alfajor 🇦🇷	filled biscuit sandwich	*Un alfajor de chocolate para el viaje.* A chocolate alfajor for the journey.

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06 · PLATOS TÍPICOS CLASSIC DISHES

ESPAÑOL	ENGLISH	EN UNA FRASE
el mate 🇦🇷	mate, herbal tea drink	*¿Tomamos unos mates?* Shall we have some mate?
la sobremesa	chatting at the table after a meal	*La sobremesa duró tres horas.* We sat chatting after lunch for three hours.
¡Buen provecho!	Enjoy your meal!	*—¡Buen provecho! —¡Gracias, igualmente!* —Enjoy your meal! —Thanks, you too!

¿SABÍAS QUE...?

Mate is shared from the same gourd, passed round the group, always refilled by the same person, el cebador. Saying 'gracias' when you hand it back means you don't want any more, so only say it when you've had enough!

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07

DE SOBREMESA

TABLE TALK

Things you'll say and hear around the table. When there are two versions, the second is how you'd say it in Argentina.

¿Qué vas a tomar? / ¿Qué vas a pedir?
What are you having?

Tengo un hambre...
I'm starving.

¿Me pasas la sal? / ¿Me pasás la sal?
Could you pass the salt?

¿Quieres probar? / ¿Querés probar?
Do you want to try some?

Estoy lleno. / Estoy llena.
I'm full.

¡Qué rico está todo!
Everything is delicious!

¿Me das la receta?
Will you give me the recipe?

¡Salud!
Cheers!

¿Un poquito más?
A little more?

No, gracias, ya no puedo más.
No thanks, I can't eat another bite.

Esto está para chuparse los dedos.
This is finger-licking good.

Invito yo. / Pago yo.
My treat. / I'll pay.

¿SABÍAS QUE...?

In both countries it's polite to say '¡buen provecho!' to people who are eating, even strangers at the next table in a small restaurant. The usual reply is '¡gracias, igualmente!'

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08

¡A LA MESA!

ACTIVITIES

1 MATCH THEM UP

Write the letter of the English meaning next to each Spanish word or phrase.

1	la sartén	☐	A	to boil
2	hervir	☐	B	cream
3	la receta	☐	C	to peel
4	crujiente	☐	D	the frying pan
5	el pescado	☐	E	chatting after a meal
6	la nata	☐	F	fish (to eat)
7	pelar	☐	G	to share
8	compartir	☐	H	the recipe
9	amargo	☐	I	bitter
10	la sobremesa	☐	J	crunchy

2 ¿VERDADERO O FALSO?

Read each sentence and circle V (true) or F (false).

1. El pez del mar y el pescado del plato son lo mismo en español. **V** **F**
2. En Argentina, la manteca es mantequilla. **V** **F**
3. El gazpacho es una sopa que se toma fría. **V** **F**
4. Si una comida está sosa, le falta sabor. **V** **F**
5. El asado es un postre típico argentino. **V** **F**
6. 'Invito yo' significa que vas a pagar tú. **V** **F**

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3 ABUELA'S RECIPE

Complete the recipe for tortilla de patatas with the words from the box.

pela | corta | sartén | aceite | huevos | sal | plato | fríe

Primero, _____ las patatas y _____ la cebolla en trozos pequeños. Calienta mucho _____ de oliva en una _____ y _____ las patatas a fuego lento. Bate seis _____ con una pizca de _____ y mézclalos con las patatas. Cuando esté cuajada por un lado, dale la vuelta con un _____ grande. ¡Buen provecho!

4 SPAIN OR ARGENTINA?

Write the word used in Argentina next to the one used in Spain.

- **la patata** → _____
- **los guisantes** → _____
- **la fresa** → _____
- **el filete** → _____
- **el melocotón** → _____
- **la nevera** → _____
- **el aguacate** → _____
- **la nata** → _____

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5 SOPA DE LETRAS

Find the 12 words. They go across → or down ↓.

T	U	L	L	M	V	R	U	P	C	C	I
R	P	A	P	A	R	C	B	J	U	P	J
E	Q	N	C	H	U	R	R	O	S	M	A
C	U	P	M	F	H	V	A	D	R	B	G
E	E	J	E	H	U	N	S	M	A	T	E
T	S	N	R	C	E	F	A	P	N	S	T
A	O	I	E	O	V	T	D	I	O	A	M
N	H	E	C	F	O	E	O	H	H	R	A
R	U	F	P	O	S	T	R	E	I	T	J
P	A	E	L	L	A	A	E	O	T	E	M
V	O	L	L	A	U	L	E	S	V	N	B
P	H	O	R	N	O	T	N	N	N	N	D

QUESO
PAELLA
HUEVO
HORNO
RECETA
POSTRE
SARTEN
MATE
PAPA
CHURROS
OLLA
ASADO

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6 YOUR FAVOURITE DISH

Describe your favourite dish in five or six sentences: what it is, what's in it, how it's made and when you eat it. Use at least six words from this dictionary.

Try: Mi plato favorito es... Lleva... Primero se... Después... Está riquísimo porque... Lo como cuando...

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ANSWERS

1 · MATCH THEM UP

1–D, 2–A, 3–H, 4–J, 5–F, 6–B, 7–C, 8–G, 9–I, 10–E

2 · ¿VERDADERO O FALSO?

1 F, 2 V, 3 V, 4 V, 5 F, 6 V

3 · ABUELA'S RECIPE

1. pela, 2. corta, 3. aceite, 4. sartén, 5. fríe, 6. huevos, 7. sal, 8. plato

4 · SPAIN OR ARGENTINA?

la patata → la papa; la fresa → la frutilla; el melocotón → el durazno; el aguacate → la palta; los guisantes → las arvejas; el filete → el bife; la nevera → la heladera; la nata → la crema

6 · YOUR FAVOURITE DISH

Any answer that uses six words from the dictionary is delicious. Read it out loud and share it at your next meal!

5 · SOPA DE LETRAS

T	U	L	L	M	V	R	U	P	C	C	I
R	P	A	P	A	R	C	B	J	U	P	J
E	Q	N	C	H	U	R	R	O	S	M	A
C	U	P	M	F	H	V	A	D	R	B	G
E	E	J	E	H	U	N	S	M	A	T	E
T	S	N	R	C	E	F	A	P	N	S	T
A	O	I	E	O	V	T	D	I	O	A	M
N	H	E	C	F	O	E	O	H	H	R	A
R	U	F	P	O	S	T	R	E	I	T	J
P	A	E	L	L	A	A	E	O	T	E	M
V	O	L	L	A	U	L	E	S	V	N	B
P	H	O	R	N	O	T	N	N	N	N	D

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¡BUEN PROVECHO!

ENJOY EVERY BITE

Now you can shop, cook, order and talk about food in Spanish. The best way to practise? Share a meal and let the sobremesa do the rest.

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